

YANG LIWEI

Born 1965

The Chinese word for astronaut is "taikonaut".

A former fighter pilot, Yang became the first man from China in space in 2003 when he flew the Shenzhou 5 capsule for 14 orbits around Earth. Until then, only Russia and the United States had undertaken manned space missions. Yang's flight marked the start of China's manned space programme, and the country has plans for a space station in the 2020s.



Artist's impression of the Shenzhou 5 craft

DATA FILE



KEY ACHIEVEMENT: The first Chinese astronaut to go into space



COUNTRY OF ORIGIN: People's Republic of China



YEAR OF ACHIEVEMENT: 2003